DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Does Shema Remember Egypt?

Derech Hashem 4:4:9

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraph 9 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 21 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

The Rabbi reviewed the chapter so far. The first verse of Shema contains three concepts: Yihud Hashem, the unity of God; accepting the yoke of Heaven; and mesirut nefesh, giving our lives to God as an expression of our belief in His unity. Barukh Shem Kevod Malkhuto LeOlam VaEd is said silently because we believe that God's glory will one day be fully revealed, but we cannot see it now.

The three paragraphs of Shema complete these ideas. The first paragraph is about accepting God's sovereignty, loving Him and believing in His oneness, and this must permeate every part of life: teaching it to our children, putting it on the doorposts, living with it when we walk and travel. "It's not just something which you think about in the morning."

The second paragraph: the yoke of misvot

On the second paragraph the Ramhal says only one thing: in it a person accepts the yoke of the misvot. Why does that belong here? Because doing the misvot is the expression of truly accepting God's sovereignty. "If you really accept the king's authority, then you'll listen to what the king says." The first paragraph never mentions misvot; the second does.

A participant asked whether accepting the yoke also leads to perfection. The Rabbi answered that it all follows: doing misvot shows that you really believe He is King, it means you have a relationship with Him, and that relationship is perfection.

The third paragraph: sisit or Egypt?

Here the Rabbi pointed out something very interesting. The Ramhal seems to contradict the Gemara in Berakhot. The Gemara explains the three paragraphs as Yihud Hashem, the yoke of misvot, and then the paragraph of sisit, which is said so that we remember to do the misvot: we look at the sisit and are reminded of them. That gives a neat flow: accept the yoke, show it by doing the misvot, and remember them by looking at the sisit.

The Ramhal instead says the main purpose of the third paragraph is to remember the Exodus from Egypt. For him, the reason for saying it is really its last sentence, "I am Hashem your God

who took you out of the land of Egypt." The Rabbi explained that there are two things in the third paragraph: misvot, which connects to the second paragraph, and the Exodus. When you include a paragraph, you quote all of it.

A participant suggested that the reason is the command to remember the Exodus twice a day. The Rabbi agreed that Shema is a way to fulfil that misvah, while noting that if someone cannot say Shema, for example because his body is not clean, he can still remember Egypt and fulfil it.

Egypt as an iron crucible

Why is remembering Egypt so important? The Ramhal goes back to the sin of Adam, after which humanity was left degraded, as learned in Part 1. God chose Avraham and his descendants and set them apart, but they did not yet have the strength and light to be established as a complete and perfect nation, because the original darkness and pollution had not left them.

So they had to go down to Egypt and be enslaved, and through that servitude they were refined "like gold in a crucible." God then brought them up and redeemed them, and they reached the state of Adam before the sin. From then on they were established as a complete nation, cleaving to God and crowned by Him.

This rectification had an everlasting effect; all the good that comes to us comes through it. That is why we are commanded to remember it and mention it every day: by doing so, the light of that rectification shines on us again and stays alive in our lives.

Questions from the group

A participant asked why, if we reached such a level, we are not on it today. Another answered: the golden calf and the complaints. The Rabbi added that this is a second place where the Ramhal seems to differ from the Gemara, which says that the pollution of Israel ceased at Matan Torah, not at the Exodus. He suggested one can get around this by seeing the Exodus and receiving the Torah, 49 days apart, as one great event. But forty days later came the golden calf, and the Gemara says the pollution returned. Still, some light from that first rectification remains, and that is why it is worth saying every day.

A participant recalled from Rashi that every punishment contains an element of the golden calf, and the Rabbi agreed.

Why does suffering refine?

The Rabbi then asked the deeper question: why should suffering in Egypt refine a people and bring them to the state of Adam before the sin? A participant answered that affliction makes a person cry out and look to Hashem for help. The Rabbi accepted this as part of it, but said there is something deeper, touched on at the beginning of Part 2: suffering itself has the power to refine.

He quoted the verse said every Shabbat morning, "Rabbot raot saddik," "many are the troubles of the righteous." The Zohar reads it as: many troubles make a person a saddik. Beyond bringing a person to prayer, the idea is that the less physical a person has, the more he is able

to focus on the spiritual. Life is about balancing many values, and the more we focus on one thing, the more it comes at the expense of others.

The recording ends here; the class continues in the next recording.

Summary

- The second paragraph of Shema is acceptance of the misvot, the practical expression of accepting God as King.
- The Gemara in Berakhot sees the third paragraph as a reminder to do the misvot; the Ramhal says its main purpose is remembering the Exodus.
- Egypt was an iron crucible that refined Israel and brought them to the level of Adam before the sin, with an everlasting effect.
- The golden calf brought back the pollution, but enough light remains that recalling the Exodus daily brings it down again.
- Suffering refines because the less we are taken up with the physical, the more room there is for the spiritual.

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